ENSURING WELLNESS

Post-Covid, the health ministry has not rested on its laurels but has actively pursued the priorities that were derailed by the pandemic

By Sonali Acharjee



GETTY IMAGES

IT'S BY THE WAY A BODY COPES under strain that you judge its robustness. India traced the full Covid journey almost like a patient—sudden capture by a virus, moments of hypoxia and panic, despair and debility, pain, convalescence and then recovery. Judge by the fact that, in the end, it had rolled out the most extensive vaccination programme in the world. All of 2.2 billion vaccine doses till now. But it isn't just vaccines that the ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW) excelled in during the pandemic. Many forget that when Covid struck, we had only 14 labs to test samples. By the end of 2022, this figure stood at 1,453 government labs and 1,935 private ones, which together have a capacity to test 250,000 samples a day. The ministry also set up INSACOG, a national-level disease surveillance network of 10 genomic sampling labs. These two improvements should help significantly in the handling of any future pandemics.

Despite the pandemic having taken up a fair share of resources, the ministry has made up for lost time after 2021. Besides the increased budgeted expenditure on healthcare (2.1 per cent of GDP in FY23), there has been significant progress in expanding the coverage of Ayushman Bharat that entitles around 120 million poor families to receive a health cover of Rs 5 lakh per family for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation. As of May 2023, 51.2 million hospital admissions worth over Rs 61,501 crore had been authorised, over 28,405 hospitals empanelled and 234.2 million Ayushman cards issued.

At the start of the Modi government's second term, heavy emphasis was laid by the ministry on disease prevention. Plans were made to create 150,000 health and wellness centres by upgrading existing PHCs in urban and rural areas. The target was achieved by December 2022. By April-end, 159,585 health and wellness centres were operational. Together, the centres have done 324 million screenings for diabetes, 222 million screenings for oral cancer, 71 million for cervical cancer and 10 million for breast cancer.

ASHA workers have also been a vital cog in this. The work done by the 1.05 million such workers in the country has already shown results, with the NFHS-5 survey showing a 14.4 per cent increase in full immunisation coverage as compared to NFHS-4. Indeed, to

BOLD & BRAVE

2.2 BILLION
Covid vaccine doses administered in biggest vaccination campaign ever

120 MILLION
poor families now get Rs 5 lakh health cover under Ayushman Bharat

BUT...

Out-of-pocket health expenses still affect 55 mn Indian families annually; 17% pushed into penury*

*Source: WHO report 2022